district, to the Tuticorin division as sub-collector and joint magistrate. The two months that he spent in Tuticorin were momentous ones. Working closely with Wynch, Ashe won his trust. But in a few years, he would pay for this with his life, the only victim of a political assassination in the freedom struggle in south India.

Wynch not only despatched police reinforcements to Tuticorin as soon as the strike began, but also rushed from Tirunelveli and camped there. The day after the strike began, a reserve police force was summoned from Sivakasi. Despite news of stray violence—of stone throwing, breaking hydrants, etc.—the mill hands were remarkably non-violent. However, local Europeans, totally terrified, spent the nights at sea aboard some vessels.

The united workers were supported by the public—an indication of how the people had been mobilized politically. VOC raised a strike fund, organized food and even arranged for stopgap employment to sustain the striking workers. Many of those connected with SSNCo—K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar and T.S. Subramania 'Pandaram' Pillai[16]—not only joined VOC in organizing the strike but also contributed to the strike fund and helping in the relief work. Finally, the mill management was forced to negotiate. In direct talks with Ashe, VOC refused to yield to his intimidation. Finally, all the workers' demands were conceded. The prestige of both the mill management and the government had taken a beating.

Dethroning VOC

SSNCo's moderate directors were alarmed by the strike. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar feared the worst: 'This apprehension rose in the minds of some of us when we had the disaster in Surat. Since then, we have been led to think that it will not do to leave the country in the hands of irresponsible speakers who may put forth unsound ideas and views in the name of patriotism.'[17] Even if he could do nothing about it in the world outside, Guruswami Aiyar now set out to strip VOC of his powers in the company.

As we noted earlier, the place of politics in the running of the company was a sticking point from the beginning. Was SSNCo to stick to